Discussion Round Final Stage

Summary and Synthesis

Over the course of 60 minutes, there are two primary components that make up a round of Discussion: procedural and substantive.

- **Procedural** components provide structure and order to the round, but do not directly contribute ideas or thoughts aimed at solving the task. Examples include setting an agenda, focusing the group, and timing.
- **Substantive** components provide ideas and thoughts in order to solve the task. These involve contributing research or anecdotal evidence, or synthesizing multiple viewpoints.

The final stage of a Discussion round seeks to wrap up the major deliverables (the HOWs) and determine whether the task has been adequately solved. This stage is mostly substantive, as your group is making a final check into whether or not the HOWs have been sufficiently covered from the task.

Many groups have a student who has taken good notes and provides a summary. This is also often when some of the strongest competitors make many of the most favorable impressions on the judge by synthesizing multiple viewpoints to help launch a concluding contribution.

Synthesize Multiple Viewpoints

This is arguably the hardest (and most rewarding) activity you can perform during a Discussion round. This is when you take various points of views provided by other members of your group, verbally recapping them, then using those different viewpoints to offer a new insight. Taking Notes (covered in Discussion Round Middle Stage - Substantive Contributions) greatly improves your ability to synthesize. As does being an effective listener and critical thinker. Be sure to call out whose ideas your own stems from; this builds the credibility and buy-in from your peers in your contribution, since you clearly value their contributions enough to make a new contribution from.

Summarize Findings

Often a task will require your group to summarize their findings. Being able to summarize requires that you are Taking Notes (covered in Discussion Round Middle Stage - Substantive Contributions). A good summary should seek to aggregate all the various talking points in the discussion round. Rather than repeat the flow of what was covered, point-by-point, try to organize your notes so that if you get a chance to summarize, it is concise. If you end up not being the summarizer, but have taken good notes, pay close attention to the summary and feel free to speak up if you feel the person doing the summary missed an important point. It is also vitally important to give credit to the participant who made that substantive contribution in the round while summarizing. Don't ever claim a contribution was yours if you didn't make it!

Round Robin

Sometimes groups decide that they want to hold what's called a "round robin". This is usually in response where the task asks the group for a unanimous decision point. The goal of the round robin is to allow each person at the table the floor to essentially vote on whether they agree or disagree with the group's proposal. This almost always ends with a split group, and isn't generally that helpful to reaching consensus. Don't fall into the trap of thinking that the majority should win in a split vote: that is the antithesis of Discussion! If your group wants to hold a round robin, ensure enough time is left in order for the group to try to compromise if there is a split. Ultimately a negotiation is required between the supporters and opponents of the proposal in order to come to consensus.

Re-Visit the Consensus Question

If your group formed a Consensus Question during the opening stage, this is the phase in which the question is used to gauge the team's success. Often the student who came up with the question is allowed or asked to re-visit that question. This is much more effective at determining final success compared to Re-Read(ing) the Task (see below). Since the spotlight is given to that student at the very end of the round to repeat the question, and get the group's buy-in on the final solution, this can be a very powerful way to increase that student's rankings in the eyes of the judge.

Re-Read the Task

Most groups will read the task again at the end of the round, and ask the group whether they think they solved the task or not. This is largely a gimmick and almost never have students admitted they feel like the task wasn't properly answered. Often this happens with only minutes to spare in the round, and the group is going to agree they solved the task no matter what. If your group has used a Consensus Question, there is no need to read the task again. Try to suggest this, but be prepared again to back down if the group thinks reading the task again must be performed. Often a judge will reward a student who challenges but defers to the group decision over a student who challenges and refuses to back down. Especially when there's very little value in reading the task again. Another suggestion that has more merit is to only read the WHAT and the HOW of the task (typically the last few sentences), which reduces the time spent on this superfluous activity.

After the Round

It is important that once the round is over, that you quickly gather your belongings and exit the competition area. The judge needs time to finish their critique, enter their ranks, and head to their next round, so try to give them that space as quickly as you can. Many students thank the judge on the way out, which is fine to do, but don't make it an overly long thank you. Don't try to shake the judge's hand.

At no point during or after a round of Discussion should the judge participate. Too often judges feel it is their job to give verbal critiques of the group immediately after the round is over. This is strictly against the rules, but it is not your job to tell the judge they can't participate or give oral critiques. You should immediately seek out your coach at the tournament once you leave your round to report that judge. Your coach will hunt down their head coach and make sure they don't ever do that again!

Once you have left the table, and are well out of earshot of your judge, feel free to network and talk to your competitors about your round. Talk about your impressions of the task, how the round went, and be complimentary to others. You want to reinforce any positive impressions which may have been formed from before the round, through the round, and now after the round. You never know when you'll go up against those same students again, so gain their favorable side, and they may be easier to work with in the future.